Closeout Report: Tablet Rollout



Project Summary

- **Project:** Sauce & Spoon launched guest-facing menu tablets at two restaurant locations, Sauce & Spoon North and Sauce & Spoon Downtown, so guests can order and pay without waiting for a server. The tablets promote add-on items and coupons, speed up service, and give the team clear data to track performance. A test launch with 50 friends and family guests came first, followed by improvements before the wider launch.
- **Desired results and key success criteria:** Reduce table turn time by 30 minutes; increase daily guest count by 10%; reduce food waste by 25%; keep customer-reported technical issues below 5% each week; keep tablet checkout at one minute or less; and earn strong customer satisfaction scores in the survey.
- **Why it matters:** The project supports Sauce & Spoon's company objectives to provide an enjoyable dining experience in less than an hour, maintain a 4.5 star review rating, and keep innovating with projects like menu tablets.

Methodology

- **Hybrid approach.** The project combined traditional (plan-driven) and agile (iterative) methods.
- **Traditional, for planning and setup:** The project charter defined scope, goals, and budget. A fixed launch date, vendor negotiation, tablet installation by an electrician, POS integration, and a staff training plan were managed in sequence, with weekly vendor calls to track tasks and dependencies.
- **Agile, after the test launch:** A test launch, customer survey, and retrospective meeting gave quick feedback. The team then made small, fast improvements (simpler tablet layout, clearer payment messaging, a pre-service testing checklist, and waitstaff pacing training) instead of waiting until the end of the project.
- **Stakeholder alignment:** Regular meetings and email check-ins with the sponsor, general managers, chef, kitchen managers, and consultant. Disagreements and their decisions were recorded in the charter appendix.

Results

Performance Baseline:

	Planned	Actual	Notes
Actual Project Schedule vs Planned	Launch on Apr. 1	Launched on Apr. 23	Launched about three weeks later than planned (Apr. 23 instead of Apr. 1) because of unaccounted vacation time and unplanned operational issues; we accelerated our tasks to limit the delay
Actual Project Cost vs Planned	Training materials and fees: $10,000 Hardware and software implementation across locations: $30,000 Maintenance (IT fees): $5,000 Updated website and menu design fee: $5,000 Other customization fees: $550	Training materials and fees: $7,486 Hardware and software implementation across locations: $3,600 annually (subscription, both locations) Maintenance (IT fees): $0 (included with hardware order subscription) Updated website and menu design fee: $4,250 Other customization fees: $578	Overall, we came in well under budget ($15,914 vs. $50,550 planned), mainly because the tablets were on a subscription rather than a purchase
Planned Scope vs Delivered Scope	Install tablets at two restaurant locations Launch in Q2 (April 23) Create a plan for how to train staff on the new system	Physically installed tablets at two restaurant locations via electrician Added menus, coupons, branding, and additional content to tablets Integrated tablets with POS system Negotiated with tablet vendor over timing Created a plan for	We didn't realize how many moving pieces we were going to encounter

		training Managed waitstaff expectations and concerns Trained BOH and FOH Created system for maintenance/locking Implemented system of surveying and measuring customer satisfaction	

Key Accomplishments:

- **Initial goals met or exceeded after improvements:** table turn time reduced by 30 minutes (goal: 30), which also shortened table waits; Downtown daily guest count up 20% (goal: 10%); food waste reduced by 25% (goal: 25%); customer-reported technical issues below 5% each week (goal: below 5%); and average tablet checkout time at one minute or less.
- **Launched on April 23:** Went live on April 23, three weeks after the planned date of April 1, with tasks accelerated to limit the delay.
- **Problems solved:** A simpler layout fixed the navigation difficulty guests reported (22% found navigation difficult in the test launch). Clearer messaging now explains that tablets take cards only, with a streamlined process for guests paying cash. A pre-service testing checklist removed the glitchy tablets (12% of test guests had technical issues).
- **Not fully eliminated:** Incorrect orders (28% in the test launch) are still being reviewed across all possible causes, including the kitchen. There is no post-launch accuracy figure yet.
- **Deliverables met requirements:** Tablets were installed at both locations and integrated with the POS system. Menus, coupons, branding, and content were added. BOH and FOH staff were trained. A maintenance and locking system and a customer survey system are in place. Actual costs ($15,914 total) came in within the planned budget.
- **Positive reception:** Guests like the novelty of the tablets and how they speed things up, the look fits the Sauce & Spoon brand, and guests and waitstaff are adjusting.

Lessons Learned

- **Went well: vendor coordination.** Weekly vendor calls kept tasks and dependencies clear.

- **Went well: early feedback.** The test launch, survey, and retrospective surfaced problems (incorrect orders, navigation, cash payments, frozen tablets) while they were still easy to fix.
- **Went well: turn time.** The tablets alone did not reduce turn time. Working with the general managers and training waitstaff to be aware of guest pacing is what delivered the 30-minute reduction.
- **Went well: reliability and kitchen flow.** The pre-service testing checklist kept technical issues under 5%. Kitchen ticket flow was smooth, and the kitchen started its own operational improvements because of it.
- **Did not go well: schedule.** Unaccounted vacation time and unplanned internal operational issues at each location slowed implementation and pushed the launch from April 1 to April 23, even after tasks were accelerated. Collect everyone's availability and learn each location's history before planning.
- **Did not go well: training.** Training focused on using the tablets. Staff also needed guidance on pacing and a better understanding of how front and back of house work together. A more comprehensive, possibly two-part, training would help.
- **Did not go well: expectations.** Guests were not told up front that tablets take cards only, so cash payers had a slower, frustrating checkout. Clear messaging fixed this after the test launch.
- **Did not go well: alignment.** The general managers had different views on table turn time (Downtown sped up visits, while North let guests linger), and the debate about incorrect orders became tense. Align on objectives early and agree on how they will be measured.
- **Unforeseen benefits:** Guests enjoyed the tablets (78% signed up for the newsletter in the test launch), the new ticket flow led the kitchen to improve its operations, and costs came in lower than planned (maintenance was included with the hardware subscription).
- **Unforeseen consequences:** There were many more moving pieces than expected, cash payments caused friction, and a gap in understanding between front and back of house surfaced.
- **Key problems and effects:** Incorrect orders (28% in the test launch) led to remakes, food waste, kitchen strain, and tension between teams. Turn time stayed flat after the test launch until training changed. Navigation difficulty and frozen tablets lowered ease-of-use ratings until they were fixed.

Next Steps

- **Ongoing maintenance:** Run the pre-service testing checklist before each service, keep the maintenance and locking system working, and add each technical fix to the process manual. Plan the budget and renewal for the tablet hardware and software subscription ($3,600 annually).
- **Ongoing development:** Seydou is working with the designer to make the Birthday Club clearer on the website and tablets (only 16% of test guests signed up).
- **Open action: incorrect orders.** Seydou to check for technical issues affecting ticket accuracy, and the team to review all possible causes, including the

kitchen. Deanna and Carter to continue the order-return policy discussion as an operations item.

- **Open action: training.** Update the waitstaff training (more comprehensive, possibly two parts) and hold sessions where front and back of house share what each team does.
- **Open action: back of house capacity.** Help BOH scale up for higher order volume and revisit kitchen staffing and payroll using the results.
- **Open action: cash checkout.** Confirm the improved cash payment process works well at both locations, such as asking guests how they will pay and making a register easy for servers to reach.
- **Risks for the next quarter:** Incorrect orders could undo the food waste gains and hurt reviews. Higher guest counts could overload the kitchen if BOH capacity does not grow. Pressure to speed up turns could hurt the guest experience where guests like to linger. Tablet reliability could slip if the checklist is skipped.
- **Ownership:** Molly Edwards takes over as project manager for the next rollouts. Deanna remains sponsor and owns operations decisions, the general managers own results at their locations, and Seydou owns technical issues.
- **Recommendations for future project managers:** Keep the weekly vendor calls. Learn each location's history and everyone's availability before scheduling. Run a test launch, survey, and retrospective at every new location. Tell guests about payment options up front. Align the general managers on objectives early. Train front and back of house together.

Project Documentation Archive

- Project proposal: Sauce & Spoon Project Proposal: Menu Tablets
- Project charter: Sauce & Spoon Menu Tablet Pilot
- Project plan
- Evaluation findings presentation: Sauce & Spoon Test Launch Findings